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PRESS RELEASES

Family of Parady La and Advocacy Groups Publicly Demand Accountability After Death in ICE Custody

Family members of Parady La, joined by the ACLU of Pennsylvania, community organizers, and elected officials, held a press conference outside the Federal Detention Center (FDC) in Philadelphia to address Parady La's death while in ICE custody and to demand accountability, transparency, and systemic change.

February 5, 2026 5:00 pm

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PHILADELPHIA – Today, family members of Parady La, joined by the ACLU of Pennsylvania, community organizers, and elected officials, held a press conference outside the Federal Detention Center (FDC) in Philadelphia to address Parady La's death while in ICE custody and to demand accountability, transparency, and systemic change.

Parady La, a 46-year-old Cambodian American father and longtime Philadelphia-area resident, died on January 9,

2026, days after being detained by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) at FDC Philadelphia. ICE has stated that La was undergoing treatment for drug withdrawal when he was found unresponsive in his cell. His family says significant questions remain unanswered regarding his medical care, treatment, and the circumstances leading to his death.

At today's press conference, the La family sought to correct the public record and share who Parady La was beyond government narratives.

“When I think of my dad and the time we spent together, the word that comes to mind is adventurous. We were always on the go when I was younger, whether it was going to the park on long summer days and waiting for the Mister Softee truck to come by, visiting my uncle in Delaware, or heading to the tennis courts where he spent many hours trying to teach a young me a sport he loved deeply,” **Jazmine La, the daughter of Parady, recounted.** “Now that he's no longer here for us to continue our adventures, I will deeply cherish the ones we did have. I never felt alone when my dad was around. He was always looking out for me, introducing me to lifelong friends with kids for me to play with, making sure I was taken care of all while battling his own addiction. That's the kind of person my dad was.”

His wife, Meghan Morgan, stated, “I have known Parady for 24 years. Parady was greatly loved and we all miss him very very much. Parady was a family man– to him, family was the most important thing in his life and there was nothing he wouldn't do for us. I always knew that if I ever needed anything I could call him and he would be there no matter what! And now I have to learn to live without my person. Parady was not perfect and he struggled with addiction but

he still always showed up for his family. To us he was a provider, a caregiver and our protector.”

Parady’s niece, Lisa, stated, “He was my babysitter, my guide, and the first person I ran to for support. He taught me how to ice skate at Cobbs Creek rink, introduced me to tennis, and always made sure I felt included and safe. At every family gathering, he quietly carried the weight for everyone — manning the grill, carrying heavy loads, making sure everyone had what they needed. He showed love through his actions, making us feel seen, safe, and cared for.

Parady also carried pain. In 2005, his little brother John was shot and killed during an attempted robbery outside his home. I truly believe that loss changed him forever and worsened his struggle with addiction. He tried — many trips to rehabilitation centers — because he wanted to get better. But like many who struggle, he sometimes hid it from his family. Just this past December, I asked him how he was feeling, and just like any uncle, he didn’t want me to worry — he simply replied, “I’m getting better.” He deserved support, compassion, and care.

Instead, he was punished and neglected by a system that reduced him to nothing more than the dehumanizing label of “criminal illegal alien.” My uncle was taken from his family and community by ICE and was denied essential medical care while in their custody.”

A statement was also provided by La’s brother, Rasept, who served 27 years in the United States Coast Guard and worked closely with U.S. Customs and Border Protection before ICE was established.

I acknowledge with pride that my brother Parady struggled with addiction, a challenge that many face from adolescence through adulthood, often leading to minor infractions and

entanglement with the justice system. This is far from the portrayal ICE uses in their media campaigns, which dehumanizes immigrants. Ever since we learned about his death, our family has been in profound agony. His death was completely preventable and it happened less than 36 hours after he was taken by ICE. The pain is intolerable.

The family also announced that the ACLU of Pennsylvania has filed a Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) request with ICE and the Bureau of Prisons seeking records related to Parady La's detention, medical treatment, and death.

"Immigration status should never strip someone of dignity, due process, or their life. We are filing a FOIA request for records, footage, and procedural policies essential for transparency and a thorough investigation. Right now, we don't know the truth of what happened to Mr. La, but we do know his death was avoidable. By bringing the actions of ICE and the BOP into the light, the La family may find some solace, and we can take steps to prevent future tragedies. If the agencies fail to act in accordance with the Freedom of Information Act, we will see them in court," **said Victoria Peña-Parr, ACLU-PA fellowship attorney.**

The family and advocates outlined their core demands, including full accountability and repair for the harm caused, enforceable changes to prevent future in-custody deaths, public correction of false or misleading narratives about Parady La, and official acknowledgment of wrongdoing by ICE.

Parady La was a child born out of war and genocide that was caused by the United States. The US Wars in Southeast Asia - known as the Vietnam War - drove hundreds of thousands of refugees to the US - and 10s of thousands to Philadelphia in the 1980s. Parady was amongst these children.

He lived in Admiral Court in West Philly, he was one of the first kids to join Asian Americans United's youth program four decades ago, he went to Upper Darby High - there are thousands of ways that Philadelphia has been etched into his life and story - including the loss of his beloved younger brother 20 years ago to gun violence. Parady's detention has been part of the unprecedented level of ICE attacks in the Vietnamese, Hmong, Lao, and Cambodian community in Philly and across the country who have decades-old criminal convictions since early 2025. The Vietnamese community alone has seen nearly 800 community members deported nation-wide in just 2025.

The family stated they will continue to pursue transparency, accountability, and justice for Parady La and for all families impacted by deaths in immigration detention.

More information about the FOIA [can be found at aclupa.org/paradyla](https://aclupa.org/paradyla).

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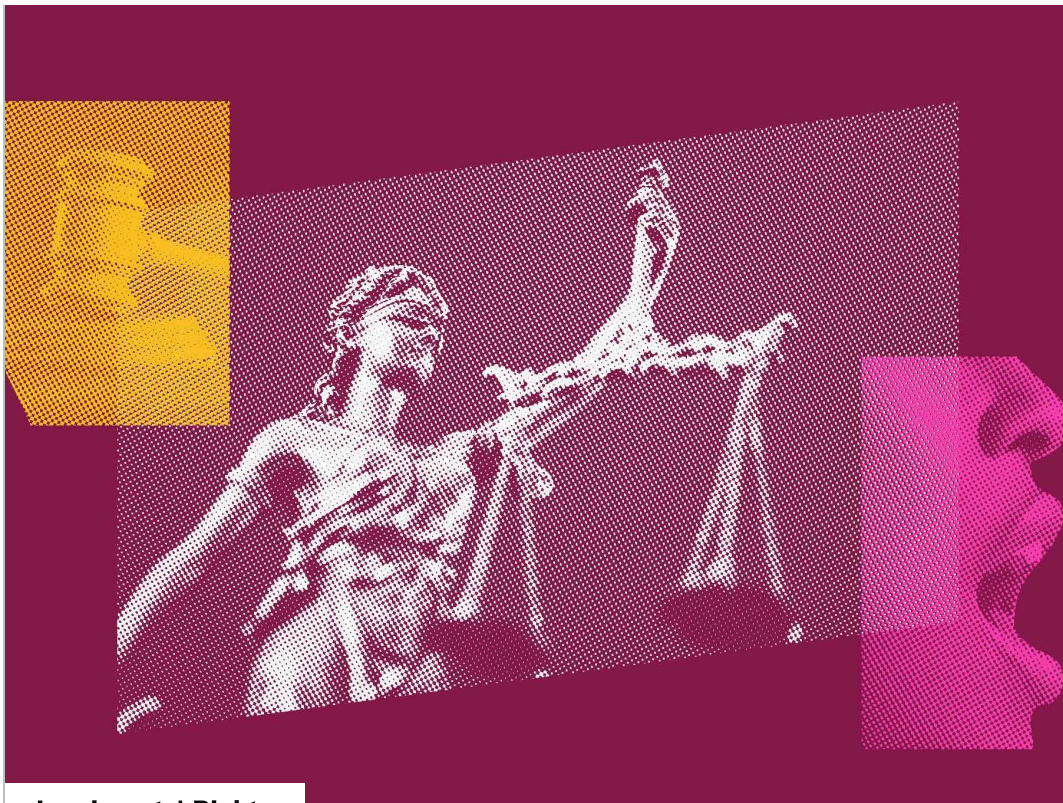
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